

Negative Keyword Match Type Cheat Sheet

Exact vs. Phrase vs. Product negatives, and the one mistake that quietly undoes them all.

The two negative match types

Type	Blocks	Example
Negative Exact	Only that exact search term (plus very close spelling variants)	Negative exact "free shipping" blocks only the search "free shipping"
Negative Phrase	Any search term that contains the phrase, in order	Negative phrase "kids" blocks "kids water bottle" and "water bottle"

Negative Product (auto/PAT campaigns)

A third option, available on Auto and Product Attribute Targeting campaigns: Negative Product targeting excludes a specific competitor ASIN from your auto-matching, rather than blocking a search term. Use it when your ad keeps showing on a competitor's product page with zero conversions.

Which one to use, and when

- Default to **Negative Phrase** when a whole theme is irrelevant — it catches every variation of that theme without you having to list each one individually.
- Use **Negative Exact** when only one specific search term is the problem, but close variants of it still convert — Negative Phrase would block those too.
- Use **Negative Product** on Auto/PAT campaigns when a specific competitor ASIN is eating spend with no orders.
- When in doubt, start narrower with Negative Exact — you can always widen to Negative Phrase later, but a too-broad negative phrase can silently block converting traffic you never notice you lost.

The one mistake that undoes all of this

Negatives only work if they're applied at the right level. A negative added to one ad group doesn't stop that same search term from triggering a different ad group or campaign targeting the same product. If several campaigns can match the same search term, add the negative at the campaign level, or repeat it in every sibling campaign — otherwise you'll keep re-discovering the same bleeder in next week's report.